Activity 6: Airbnb: Recover Trust Across a Service Ecosystem

Objective: Champion the service brand during failure and recovery Expected output:
Service-recovery playbook with authority matrix and three customer messages Primary source:
https://news.airbnb.com/about-us/

Goal

Use Airbnb's public description of its community marketplace to design brand-consistent recovery across customer, provider and platform roles.

Real-world scenario

Airbnb describes itself as a community built around connection, enabled by hosts offering stays and experiences to guests through its platform.

A Singapore experience-booking platform faces a same-day provider cancellation that disrupts a family's celebration. The platform, provider and payment partner must coordinate recovery.

Evidence boundary

Public case facts and fictional learner data must never be mixed. Every numerical or organisational training input is labelled as an assumption.

Training assumptions / guardrails

- The booking platform, incident, family and financial amounts are fictional and not an Airbnb event.
- The booking value is S$480 and an alternative provider is available at S$620 two hours later.
- Frontline agents may approve S$150 without escalation; safety and fraud flags require specialist review.
- The promise is 'Local moments, made dependable'.

Questions

1. What outcome, process and interaction fairness does the customer need?
2. Who owns the recovery when value is co-created by several parties?
3. What authority and guardrails should frontline employees have?
4. What evidence would show confidence is restored and the system improved?

Detailed activity procedure

Step 1: Map the ecosystem

Identify customer, provider, platform, payment partner and support roles, dependencies and decision rights.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 2: Define the recovery objective

State the practical outcome, emotional need, time constraint and non-negotiable safeguards.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 3: Run the recovery loop

Design recognition, ownership, stabilisation, resolution, confidence restoration and learning actions.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 4: Build the decision matrix

Set frontline authority, escalation thresholds, remedy options and communication cadence for four incident levels.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 5: Draft communications

Write first acknowledgement, progress update and closure message using verified facts and respectful language.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 6: Close the loop

Record root cause, provider action, platform action, owner, due date and verification evidence.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Deliverable

Service-recovery playbook with authority matrix and three customer messages

Acceptance criteria

The playbook protects outcome/process/interaction fairness, assigns ecosystem ownership, respects authority limits, and closes with a verified improvement action.

Reflection and debrief questions

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What evidence would you request before investing or scaling?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Facilitator debrief

Compare recommendations against relevance, distinctiveness, deliverability and evidence quality. Surface unsupported causal claims. Close by naming one decision, one owner and one validation action.

Source note

Source accessed 17 August 2026: https://news.airbnb.com/about-us/